

History & Folklore As its name suggests, viper's bugloss was once considered a preventative and remedy for viper bite. In his 1656 *The Art of Simpling*, herbalist William Coles described the plant: "its stalks all to be speckled like a snake or viper; and is a most singular remedy against poison and the sting of scorpions." Four years earlier, the English herbalist Nicholas Culpeper had praised its action against "the biting of vipers."

Medicinal Actions & Uses In many respects, viper's bugloss is similar to borage (*Borago officinalis*, p. 179), in that both herbs have a sweat-inducing and diuretic effect if taken internally. Viper's bugloss has also been taken to treat chest conditions, as its mucilage soothes dry coughs and encourages expectoration. The significant mucilage content in viper's bugloss has also proved helpful in treating skin conditions. Prepared in a poultice or plaster, it is an effective balm for boils and carbuncles. In recent times, this herb has fallen out of use, due partly to lack of interest in its medicinal potential, and partly to its pyrrolizidine alkaloids, which in isolation are toxic. Viper's bugloss may be safely used externally on unbroken skin.

Caution Do not take internally.



Viper's bugloss makes a soothing poultice for treating boils and carbuncles.

Eclipta prostrata syn. *E. alba* (Asteraceae) Trailing Eclipta

Description Multi-branched annual growing to 2 ft (60 cm). Has lance-shaped leaves and white flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Trailing eclipta is native to Africa, Asia, and Australia. It is now found throughout the tropics, being particularly common in India, China, and Queensland and New South Wales in Australia. It is harvested in early autumn.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents Trailing eclipta contains triterpenoid saponins, including ecliptine and alpha-terthienylmethanol, isoflavonoids, and phytosterols.



Trailing eclipta is taken in India and China to stop premature graying of the hair.

History & Folklore Trailing eclipta is first mentioned in herbal literature in the Chinese *Tang Materia Medica* of 659 CE. The herb contains a black pigment that has been used to color the hair in India, and mothers wash babies' heads in a decoction of the leaves to encourage hair growth. It is also used as an ink for tattooing. The leaves are also eaten as a vegetable.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Trailing eclipta has remarkably similar uses in Ayurvedic and Chinese herbal medicine. In both of these traditions, a decoction is used to invigorate the liver; to prevent premature graying of the hair; and to staunch bleeding, especially from the uterus. In the Chinese tradition, the herb is considered a yin tonic; in Ayurvedic medicine it is thought to prevent aging. In the Caribbean, the juice is sometimes taken for asthma and bronchitis. Trailing eclipta is also used there as a treatment for enlarged glands, as well as for dizziness, vertigo, and blurred vision.

Research Several laboratory experiments have shown that eclipta regulates enzyme levels within the liver and exerts a protective activity on it.

Embelia ribes (Myrsinaceae) Embelia

Description Climber with short, elliptical leaves, white or white-green flowers, and round red or black fruits.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to India and Southeast Asia, embelia grows in hilly regions. The fruit is harvested when ripe.

Part Used Fruit.

Constituents Embelia contains naphthaquinones, including embelin. Embelin stimulates the production of estrogen and progesterone, and it may have a contraceptive effect.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Embelia has been used in Asia as a home remedy for expelling worms. The herb is also diuretic and relieves flatulence, and is used for indigestion, colic, constipation, and debility.

Cautions Use only under professional supervision. Do not take during pregnancy.

Emblica officinalis (Euphorbiaceae) Indian Gooseberry

Description Deciduous tree with feathery leaves, pale green flowers, and round pale green or yellow fruit. Also known as amla.

Habitat & Cultivation Indian gooseberry grows in China, India, and Southeast Asia and is widely cultivated for its fruit.

Part Used Fruit.

Constituents Indian gooseberry contains tannins, polyphenols, flavonoids, a fixed oil, and a volatile oil.

History & Folklore The Indian gooseberry features in a 7th-century Ayurvedic medical text. The sage Muni Chyawan reputedly restored his vitality with this fruit.

Medicinal Actions & Uses The astringent Indian gooseberry is given to allay the effects of aging and to restore the organs. In Ayurvedic medicine, the fruit juice is given to strengthen the pancreas of diabetics. It is one of the three herbs in the classic Ayurvedic herbal formula known as "Triphala."

Research Recent research suggests that Indian gooseberry might have a remarkably wide range of potential medicinal benefits. A study in Kerala, India, showed that it may have protective activity against liver cancer. Other studies indicate potential anti-inflammatory and fever-inhibiting effects, and a cholesterol-lowering action. A study undertaken in Bombay concluded that the fruit might prove useful in the treatment of acute pancreatitis.